



Identification of Research Gaps Through Literature Review

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Defining Research Gap

Research Gap - a topic or area that has not yet been explored or is underexplored which limits the ability of researchers to reach a conclusion for a given question.

The Gap, could be in the population, sample, location, method, data, analysis, hypothesis, research question, variables, conditions, etc.

**There are no limits to the gaps
when perspectives are in question.**

Importance of Research Gaps

To a student undertaking research:

- It provides insights to the Problem Statement
- It helps improve the objective of the research
- It gives ideas to the methodology
- It helps with the suggestion to future research

Research
Contribution

Research
Uniqueness

Common Challenges in Identifying Research Gaps

1. Effort of dealing with an enormous amount of information:

There could be a lot of unanswered questions in an area of your interest. So you might get overwhelmed with the number of research gaps you stumble upon and feel confused about which one you should focus on.

2. Difficulty of searching in an organized manner:

Some researchers may find it difficult to organize the information they have gathered. One can easily lose ideas if they are not noted properly.

3. Hesitation in questioning established norms:

Some researchers are not confident enough to challenge the existing knowledge in their field and may hesitate to question what others have claimed in their work.



Identifying Gaps in Literature: Conventional Way

1

Look for
inspiration in
published
literature

2

Seek help
from your
research
advisor

3

Use digital
tools to seek
out topics or
cited papers

4

Check the
websites of
influential
journals

5

Make a note
of your
queries

6

Research each
question

Research Gap is more than just this...

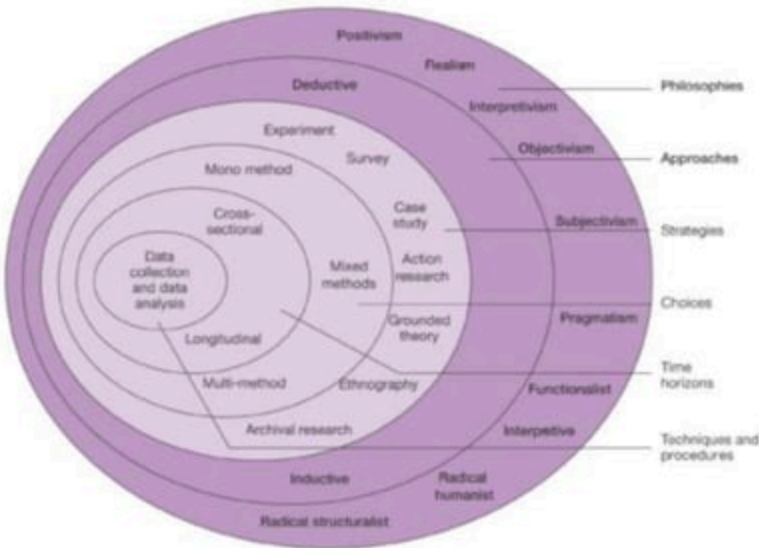


Research Gap Analysis

Research Gap is a problem. And because it lacks the backing of proper and adequate literature, it needs to be explored. Therefore in the analysis of conducting a research gap, it must:

1. **Identity the broad area**
2. **It requires a research on its own**
3. **It must have a scientific method to analyse the gap/s**
4. **It checks on the viability of the gap – thoroughly**
5. **It is very selective and discriminative to the literature**
6. **It should have an expected outcome**
7. **It should be evidence base (and no mere hypotheticals)**

Identifying Gaps in Literature: Scientific Way



Three fundamental questions:

- The **ontological** question i.e. what is the form and nature of reality – **what you see**
- The **epistemological** question i.e. what is the basic belief about knowledge (i.e. what can be known) – **why you see like that**
- The **methodological** question i.e. how can the researcher go about finding out whatever s/he believes can be known.

(Guba and Lincoln, 1994)



Thank You

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